

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Facing violence and seeing progress

Englewood nonprofit's members have been killed as toll has fallen

By **Tess Kenny**
Chicago Tribune

There are days when Charles McKenzie wants to give up. After his 1-month-old niece was shot in the head. Or when his friend was shot to death in the South Side neighborhood where they both grew up. Hours after celebrating his birthday earlier this summer, when he got the call that gunfire had killed someone else he considered family. But he persists in hopes that one day, change will stick. “I gotta keep running, keep running, keep running,” McKenzie said. “Until I can’t run no more.” McKenzie, 36, is the founder of Englewood First Responders, a nonprofit organization primarily composed of at-risk youth and young adults that for six years now has worked to prevent and clamp down on violence in Englewood and other areas across the city — even as it faces the heartbreak of that violence head-on. Since last summer, Englewood First Responders members have had to mourn two of their own who were killed by gunfire. But for those that remain, their work continues.

Despite insistence from the White House that Chicago is in need of a federal crime crackdown, efforts by both elected officials and people like McKenzie to prevent shootings and disrupt cycles of violence have been — and are — in force. The city is now well into its fourth consecutive year of declining violent crime. Through late August, Chicago had recorded 266 homicides in 2025, a 32% decline in killings from the same period in 2024, while total shooting incidents are down 36%.

Turn to Anti-violence, Page 2



Eddie Vallejo gives instructions to striking Mauser Packaging Solutions workers on Thursday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

STILL OUT ON THE LINE

As federal immigration enforcement is set to ramp up, a strike over immigration protections in Little Village continues this Labor Day

By **Talia Soglin and Nell Salzman**
Chicago Tribune

On the Mauser Packaging Solutions plant floor, laborers do the dirty work of reconditioning steel containers used to transport chemicals. The workers blast residue off the “dirties,” clean them and repaint them to be used again. As they work, the chemicals in the air irritate their eyes. But for the last 12 weeks, the workers, many of whom are Latino immigrants, haven’t been cleaning or painting anything inside the facility at the end of a quiet residential street in Little Village. Instead they have been outside the plant picketing, demanding the company provide them with safer workplace conditions — and protect them from federal immigration enforcement raids.

More than 100 workers, members of the International Brotherhood of Teamsters Local 705, have struck through the summer’s heat and storms for their demands. And this Labor Day, as Chicago braces for the possibility of a federal immigration crackdown this week, they are still out on the line. The workers have won support from powerful Democratic allies, including Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson, U.S. Rep. Jesús “Chuy” García and Vermont’s Sen. Bernie Sanders. But so far, they say, Oak Brook-based Mauser hasn’t met their demands. Workers unanimously rejected the company’s last, best and final contract offer to the union last month, according to the Teamsters. Their contract expired at the end of April, and they walked off

Turn to Striking, Page 4

More ICE to Chicago, Noem confirms

Department of Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem acknowledged Sunday an ICE surge coming to Chicago; says National Guard deployment is up to President Trump.

CHICAGOLAND, PAGE 3

At summit, 10 nations aspire to counter US

China-dominated alliance’s programs, aims still indistinct

By **Christopher Bodeen**
Associated Press

TAIPEI, Taiwan — Russian President Vladimir Putin, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and leaders of eight other nations are meeting in northern China for the latest summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization in a possible challenge to often incoherent approaches by the United States to trade and regional conflicts. The 10-member group scheduled to gather Sunday and Monday in the port city of Tianjin has grown in size and influence over the past 24 years, even while its goals and programs remain murky and name recognition low. Some call it the scariest grouping you have never heard of. The full membership includes

Russia, Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan. Originally seen as a foil to U.S. influence in Central Asia, the original organization picked up four new members with the addition of India and Pakistan in 2017, Iran in 2023 and Belarus in 2024. Some of those are clear foes of the West, especially Iran and close Russian ally Belarus. Others including India, China and Russia have a more nebulous relationship, either because of Washington’s wobbly stance on Russia’s war with Ukraine or because of chaos surrounding U.S. tariffs that have upended key trading relationships with countries such as China and India. The SCO’s two-day summit may shed more light on issues surrounding the group’s activities and intentions. Since its 2001 founding, the

Turn to Summit, Page 8



Olena Konovaliuk, right, of the Donbas region of eastern Ukraine, hugs Marta Matskiv during a rally Aug. 24 outside the Wrigley Building in Chicago to celebrate Ukraine’s Independence Day and to protest the war in Ukraine. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘Donbas is Ukraine. Free us all’

Local Ukrainians oppose Putin’s demands as US-led peace talks stall

By **Angie Leventis Lourgos**
Chicago Tribune

Olena Konovaliuk of Chicago fears she might never again see her family in the Donbas region of eastern Ukraine, where she was born and raised, as Russian President Vladimir Putin demands the land be relinquished to Moscow during ongoing U.S.-led peace talks. Giving up Donbas — or any

portion of the war-torn nation — is unfathomable to Konovaliuk and many other locals of Ukrainian descent, who insist their entire homeland must be sovereign without exception or partial surrender. “This sounds threatening to me because my family is still there. It is like saying, ‘Please take off your arm and give it to us,’” she said. “I know that there are people ... in the eastern region that are still fighting. They still have a

pro-Ukrainian mindset and they don’t want that connection to Russia.” The 31-year-old mother of two fled her hometown of Luhansk in the Donbas region in 2014 when Russian-backed forces illegally seized control of the area, a precursor to the full-scale war that began in February 2022 and rages on today. **Turn to Ukraine, Page 4**



Can’t drop the ball under bright lights

The Bears open Sept. 8 on “Monday Night Football” against the Vikings at Soldier Field. If the offense isn’t ready for prime time, there will be nowhere to hide. **Chicago Sports**

